

Chapter 49_2: With You

The sun had just set and the sky darkened completely. The thick clouds overhead seemed even denser, and the distant mountains outside the window resembled towering beasts that stood between heaven and earth, staring down at everyone with a forbidding gaze that filled people with fear.

The village could no longer be heard making any human sounds. Every household had tightly closed their doors and windows, and even the dogs did not bark. In the shabby hall, a wooden board was laid out as a dining table, with several people sitting around it.

"Qiu Lan! Hurry up!" the woman cursed. The woman holding the child rushed through the door and placed the last dish on the table.

She seemed afraid to sit at the table to eat, instead holding a bowl of some vegetable soup alone and hiding in the next room.

"Please don't be polite, you two." The woman squeezed her shrewd black bean eyes and pushed the dishes on the table toward them.

Though called dishes, there was actually no meat at all—a bowl of wild vegetable soup, a bowl of pickled shepherd's purse, and a bowl of porridge where no rice grains could be seen, with an egg beaten into it, which was the only substantial dish.

The woman stood up and ladled a bowl of porridge for each of them, placing it in front of them. The fool Er Lang was not at the table either, and opposite sat only that lame man with a sinister face, silently wolfing down his food.

While eating, he did not forget to stare at the two of them through the rim of his rice bowl.

As soon as Ning Fu Yi picked up the bowl of porridge, the corners of her mouth involuntarily turned upward, and she said to Chu Qing Qiu with a smile: "Auntie, this porridge is quite good."

Chu Qing Qiu naturally discovered the problem even earlier than her. There was medicine in the porridge—it should be some kind of folk remedy, presumably with the effect of making people drowsy.

But cultivators' bodies were different from ordinary people, and these drugs had no effect on them. So Ning Fu Yi drank it down without changing expression or heartbeat, making the woman beam with joy.

After the meal, the woman arranged them in two earthen rooms. The rooms were not large, extremely dusty, with only a flickering oil lamp providing a dim yellow light.

Listening to the woman's footsteps gradually receding, Ning Fu Yi surveyed her surroundings. The roof leaked a large water stain, the walls were built of stone and earth, and the corners were scattered with wood ash, with several talismans¹ pasted on them.

This room had no windows, not even a skylight. It didn't seem like a room, but rather like a tomb.

Ning Fu Yi walked over with her hands behind her back and tore off the talismans, then used her sleeve to sweep away the dust and dead flying insects on the bed, turning over to lean against the headboard.

She lightly knocked on the wall.

After a long while, two thumping sounds came from the other side of the wall—Chu Qing Qiu's response.

Ning Fu Yi immediately smiled. She took out the divine sword that had been shrunk to palm size from her prayer bead², and turned to poke at the wall twice. More broken stones and dust fell rustling down, creating a hole as thick as a fist.

"Divine Venerable." Ning Fu Yi pressed her eye to the hole and spoke to Chu Qing Qiu.

Through the hole, she could see Chu Qing Qiu's hair. She was also sitting with her back against this spot. The oil lamp's light fell on her hair, creating a warm sun-like halo.

"Mm." Chu Qing Qiu opened her mouth.

"I guess after I fall asleep, they will come to take me away. Then we'll be able to know what they want to do."

Chu Qing Qiu: "Mm."

"If I'm taken away and Divine Venerable is alone here, will you be afraid?" Ning Fu Yi suddenly asked.

Chu Qing Qiu didn't speak, only let out a cold snort from her nose as her answer.

"This place is too strange, and every person is strange." Ning Fu Yi smiled and didn't say more, turning to lean back against the wall, taking a strand of hair in her hand to play with, waiting for whatever was to come.

Not only was she unafraid, she was even somewhat expectant. Ning Fu Yi braided the hair into a small twist, her eyes revealing a hint of mischief.

The two were silent for a while longer, when Chu Qing Qiu suddenly spoke, her tone seeming to suppress something: "Do you hear singing?"

"No." Ning Fu Yi said.

"First break the hand, second break the waist, count to three and hang up high." Chu Qing Qiu repeated the words she heard.

"Fourth play with mud, fifth eat grass, the sixth one is..."

Her voice stopped abruptly. Ning Fu Yi put down the braided twist in her hand and coldly narrowed her eyes: "And then?"

"Nothing more." Chu Qing Qiu said.

Ning Fu Yi's heart suddenly sank. The surroundings fell into silence again. The sound of rustling clothes came from Chu Qing Qiu's side, as if she had curled up her body.

After a while, Chu Qing Qiu spoke again, her voice somewhat less calm: "Ning Fu Yi..."

"What is it?" Ning Fu Yi turned back. Through that hole, she saw Chu Qing Qiu's curled-up knees and the white bone³ she was gripping tightly in her hand.

"Does Divine Venerable want me to accompany you to sleep?" Her heartstrings trembled as she opened her mouth to ask.

Footnotes:

1. **Talismans (符纸)**: Paper charms with magical symbols written on them, traditionally used in Chinese culture to ward off evil spirits or provide protection
2. **Prayer bead (一念珠)**: A magical storage item that can hold and shrink objects, commonly used by cultivators in Chinese fantasy
3. **White bone (白骨)**: Chu Qing Qiu's weapon/spiritual item, often mentioned throughout the story